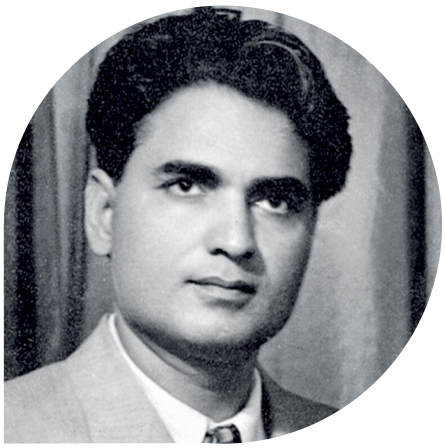
Kamal Amrohi

(1918-1993)

A poet by temperament, one of the quartet that penned the chaste Urdu lines for K. Asif's *Mughal-E-Azam*, he had an uncanny way of making the leading lady breathe soul into his rippling canvases. *Mahal* (1949), "India's first horror film", spun its web around a wraith...a memorable Madhubala. *Daaera* (1953) is an unbelievably undervalued portrayal of the condition of women, with Meena Kumari confined metaphorically within four walls. *Pakeezah* (1972) bears his most legible signature: opulent sets, minimalist acting, grandiose picturisations of haunting melodies. *Razia Sultan* (1983) paled in comparison. His dream project, *Aakhri Mughal*, alas, stayed a dream.



Bimal Roy

(1909-1966)



Coloured by the neo-realism of Vittorio de Sica's *The Bicycle Thieves* (1948) and the rich Indian romantic tradition alike, Roy confected a masterful blend—lithe of frame, almost melodic, but tossed about by inner storms. His oeuvre includes such imperishable works as *Do Bigha Zamin* and *Parineeta* (1953), *Devdas* (1955), *Madhumati* (1958, an uncharacteristic ghost story), *Sujata* (1959), *Parakh* (1960), *Kabuliwala* (1961) and *Bandini* (1963). Alternating between Salil Chaudhary and S.D. Burman, his soundtracks are still a pull on YouTube. The documentaries on the Bengal Famine and Vivekananda show where he was anchored.

Raj Kapoor

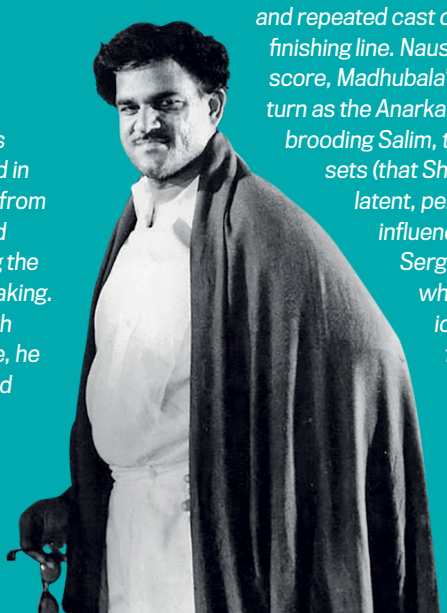
(1924-1988)

Son of actor-theatre director Prithviraj, he was to the cinema born. Venturing into direction at age 24 with *Aag* (1948), a portrait of an artist, he established himself as an actor, director and oftentimes editor with *Barsaat* (1949), *Awara* (1951), *Shree 420* (1955), a triptych that integrated entertainment with the Nehruvian ethos and pretty much laid down the DNA of popular Indian cinema. As he went from Tramp to Showman, from socialist-era dramas based around class to more big-budget, self-indulgent epics, the yen for fabulous music, often baroque visuals and the Chaplinesque acting stayed a constant.



K.Asif

(1922-1971)



As soon as he landed in Bombay from Etawah, he busied himself in learning the alphabet of filmmaking. A grand debut with Phool (1945) aside, he unarguably earned his legend status as the creator of Mughal-E-Azam (1960), which took 12 years and repeated cast changes to get to the finishing line. Naushad's raga-strewn score, Madhubala's heart-scorching turn as the Anarkali to Dilip Kumar's brooding Salim, the breath-grabbing sets (that Sheesh Mahal!), and a latent, perhaps inadvertent influence of Russian auteur Sergei Eisenstein mark what is, in my opinion, the best Hindi film ever made. He couldn't see through his last project, Love and God, after its protagonist, Guru Dutt, took his own life.